key holding access control policy

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Key Holding / Access Control Policy

1. Policy Statement

At [INSERT CARE HOME NAME], the safety, security, and wellbeing of residents, staff, and visitors are paramount. Effective management of keys and access control systems is essential to ensure a safe environment, protect property, and maintain resident privacy and dignity.

We aim to:

- Prevent unauthorised access to the care home or restricted areas
- Ensure that keys are managed securely and responsibly
- Maintain a clear system of accountability for key holding and access control
- Comply with health, safety, and safeguarding requirements

2. Purpose

The purpose of this policy is to:

- Provide clear rules on the issuing, holding, and return of keys
- Prevent the loss, misuse, or duplication of keys
- Ensure staff and authorised individuals can access areas needed for care delivery safely and efficiently
- Protect residents, staff, and property from risk

3. Scope

This policy applies to:

- All staff who are issued with keys or access cards
- Contractors and authorised visitors requiring temporary access
- Residents where access permissions apply (e.g., to their rooms)

4. Roles and Responsibilities

Registered Manager:

- Oversees key holding and access control arrangements
- Maintains a master list of all issued keys and access devices
- Investigates and reports any breaches, losses, or misuse All Staff (Key Holders):
- Keep issued keys secure at all times and never share them with others
- Report lost or stolen keys immediately

- Return keys promptly when no longer required (e.g., end of employment or shift) Contractors / Visitors:
- May be issued temporary keys or escorted access where necessary
- Must return keys before leaving the premises
- Are supervised when appropriate to ensure security

5. Key Holding and Access Procedures 5.1 Key Issuing

- Keys will only be issued to authorised staff, approved by the Registered Manager.
- A key register will record the individual, date issued, and key type.
- Residents may hold keys to their rooms, subject to individual risk assessment. 5.2 Key Use
- Keys must only be used for their intended purpose.
- Staff must not remove keys from the premises unless specifically authorised.
- Keys must not be copied, loaned, or shared under any circumstances. 5.3 Key Security
- Keys not in use must be stored in a locked key cabinet or secure area.
- Master keys must be strictly controlled and accessible only to authorised senior staff.
- Lost or stolen keys will result in locks being changed if necessary. 5.4 Electronic Access Systems
- Access cards, fobs, or codes are treated with the same security as physical keys.
- PIN codes must not be shared and should be updated regularly.
- Access logs will be monitored where electronic systems are in place. 5.5 Key Return
- Keys must be returned at the end of employment, contract, or shift where required.
- Failure to return keys will be treated as a security breach and may result in disciplinary or financial action.

6. Safeguarding and Confidentiality

- Residents' rooms are private spaces; staff must knock and wait for permission before entry, unless in an emergency.
- Access to medication rooms, records, or financial areas is strictly controlled.
- Breaches of access control are considered a safeguarding and disciplinary matter.

7. Training and Awareness

- Staff will receive training on this policy at induction.
- Refresher training will be provided as part of health and safety updates.
- Staff will be reminded regularly of their responsibilities in key holding and access control.

8. Monitoring and Audit

- The Registered Manager will carry out regular audits of the key register and access logs.
- Any discrepancies or security breaches will be investigated promptly.
- Lessons learned will be shared with staff to improve practice.

9. References

- Care Quality Commission (CQC) Fundamental Standards – Regulation 12 (Safe Care and Treatment)
- Health and Safety at Work Act 1974
- Data Protection Act 2018 / UK GDPR (for secure access to confidential information)
- Safeguarding Adults Guidelines

10. Related Policies

- Safeguarding Adults Policy
- Privacy and Dignity Policy
- Resident Finance / Handling Money Policy
- Confidentiality / GDPR Policy
- Risk Assessment Policy

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